



ZERO PACK GUIDE

Custom Compostable Packaging

Choose the right packaging. Build a better brief. Make claims you can support.

A practical guide for real packaging decisions

2026 GLOBAL EDITION

Start with the packaging job, not a preselected solution

A practical guide to choosing, planning and briefing custom compostable packaging that fits your products, brand and operation.

This is a global planning guide. Australian references and international certification schemes are clearly labelled; project-specific requirements should always be confirmed for the market where the packaging will be used.

The right custom compostable packaging should protect the product, work with your packing process, present your brand well and carry only the claims supported by the evidence for that packaging.

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1. Start with the job your packaging must do

Choose packaging around the product and delivery journey first. Material and branding decisions come after the functional brief is clear.

Good custom packaging begins with a clear job, not a product name. Before comparing materials or artwork, define what the packaging needs to protect, contain, carry or present.

Consider the entire journey: packing, storage, freight, handling, opening and disposal. Packaging that looks excellent but slows fulfilment, adds unnecessary space or fails in transit is not the right solution.

Zero Pack works across custom compostable packaging. Mailers are one of our most established products, but the range extends well beyond them. Bring us the packaging problem, or a finished brief, and we can explore the right solution with you.

What to check

- What is being packed, including weight, dimensions and any fragile, sharp, liquid or heat-sensitive features
- Whether the packaging is for shipping, product protection, retail carry, garment protection, food contact or another purpose
- How the packaging will be filled, sealed, stored and handled
- Where it will be delivered and what conditions it may encounter
- What the customer should do with it after use

2. Compare packaging types

Custom compostable packaging can take many forms. The best choice depends on the product and the role the packaging plays, not which option happens to be most familiar.

A flexible mailer may be ideal for clothing or soft goods. A garment bag may be better for product protection inside a shipment. A carry bag serves a different purpose again. Fragile or structured products may need a padded or rigid solution.

Do not assume the certification or performance of one packaging type automatically applies to another. Construction, material, thickness, closures and additional layers can change what is possible and what evidence is required.

What to check

- Shipping mailers: lightweight outer packaging for suitable non-fragile products
- Garment bags: product protection and presentation for apparel
- Shopping and carry bags: retail, events, campaigns and customer carry
- Flexible bags and pouches: containment, presentation or product protection
- Padded and protective packaging: added cushioning where product risk requires it
- Layflat tubing: flexible lengths for variable products and packing processes
- Rigid and food-related packaging: developed to the confirmed product, safety and manufacturing requirements

3. Check product fit and protection

The smallest workable size is often a good starting point, but it must still allow the product to load, close and travel without putting the seams or closure under unnecessary stress.

Measure the packed product, not only the product on its own. Include folded garments, retail boxes, inserts, tissue or other items that will sit inside the packaging.

A packaging change should be tested against real handling conditions. Samples and prototypes can help confirm sizing, feel and pack-out, but final performance depends on the approved production specification.

What to check

- Allow enough clearance for efficient packing and reliable closure
- Check whether sharp corners or rigid edges could stress flexible material
- Consider moisture exposure, compression, abrasion and temperature during transit
- Avoid unnecessary empty space that increases material and freight volume
- Test the full packed product where protection is business-critical

4. Understand certification and claims

All Zero Pack compostable packaging is certified compostable.

Compostable, biodegradable, recyclable and plastic-free are not interchangeable terms. Each claim needs its own evidence, scope and customer guidance.

Recognised certification helps establish whether a product meets defined compostability requirements. Home-compostable and industrial-compostable certification relate to different conditions and should not be presented as the same thing.

The exact certification depends on the confirmed packaging and material. Relevant standards and certification schemes can include AS 5810, AS 4736, OK compost HOME and OK compost INDUSTRIAL. We confirm the certification that applies to each project.

Certification evidence should stay connected to the packaging it covers. A certificate for one material or product should not be treated as evidence for a different construction.

What to check

- Name the exact certification only when it applies to the packaging being produced
- Keep home- and industrial-compostable claims separate
- Avoid vague claims such as eco-friendly unless the intended meaning is clearly explained and supported
- Do not imply that certification guarantees acceptance by every council or processor
- Confirm any certification mark and disposal wording before artwork is approved

5. Separate certification from disposal guidance

Certification describes what a product has been tested and verified to do under defined conditions. Disposal guidance describes the pathway available to the customer in a particular place. They are related, but they are not the same question.

A certified product may not be accepted by a local kerbside organics service or commercial processor. Collection rules can depend on councils, contracts, contamination controls, infrastructure and the receiving facility.

Customer instructions should therefore match both the packaging evidence and the disposal pathway you can reasonably support. Where local rules vary, say so clearly rather than offering a universal bin instruction.

What to check

- Confirm whether the packaging is certified for home or industrial composting
- Check current local collection or processor guidance before naming a bin or service
- Keep disposal instructions clear, visible and easy to follow
- Avoid implying that compostable packaging will break down in general waste, recycling or the natural environment
- Review instructions when selling into a new market

6. Design packaging that looks like your brand

Custom packaging is a visible part of the customer experience. It should feel connected to the product and brand rather than like a generic item with a logo added at the end.

Start with a clear hierarchy: what should the customer notice first, what information must be easy to find and what can stay secondary? Leave enough space for relevant certification, disposal and production information.

Artwork requirements depend on the packaging, print method and production setup. Confirm the dieline, colour requirements, print limits, safe areas and file requirements before final artwork is prepared.

What to check

- Use supplied production artwork templates rather than guessing dimensions
- Keep logos and important copy within the approved safe area
- Confirm colour references and understand that printed material can differ from a screen
- Check small text, fine lines, reverses and barcodes at production size
- Confirm any approved certification marks and disposal wording as part of the artwork review

7. Plan quantities, budget and timing

Custom packaging is made for your order, so quantities, setup and freight are different from buying stock packaging. The right quantity balances unit economics with storage, cash flow, demand and the risk of artwork or product changes.

Custom compostable mailers are available from 2,000 units*, with the final MOQ depending on size, print, material and specification. Other packaging types can have different minimums and should be confirmed for the project.

Production and delivery timing also depend on the approved packaging and freight plan. Work backwards from the date the packaging needs to be available and allow time for scoping, pricing, artwork, approval, production and delivery.

What to check

- Use realistic order volumes rather than an aspirational forecast
- Consider how many packaging sizes are genuinely needed
- Allow for storage space and stock-management costs
- Discuss destination, delivery method and required date early
- Set a reorder point that reflects your actual production and freight plan

* Mailer MOQ only. Final MOQ depends on size, print, material and specification.

8. Build a useful supplier brief

You do not need a finished technical specification before you ask for help. You do need enough information for the supplier to understand the product, packaging job and commercial context.

A strong brief reduces back-and-forth and makes it easier to compare options properly. If a detail is unknown, mark it as open rather than guessing.

What to check

- Business name, website and destination market
- Product description, dimensions, weight and protection needs
- Current packaging and what you want to improve
- Preferred packaging type, if known
- Estimated quantity and likely reorder pattern, if applicable
- Brand colours, print expectations and artwork status
- Certification or disposal requirements
- Required delivery location and target date
- Any food-contact, barrier, closure or operational requirements

9. Decision checklist

Custom compostable packaging is likely to be worth exploring when you can define the packaging job, have a realistic quantity requirement and want the finished result to support both practical and brand goals.

A 'not yet' answer is useful. It may mean testing a simpler packaging setup, reducing the number of sizes or waiting until demand is more predictable.

What to check

- We understand what the packaging needs to do
- We can estimate the quantity we need with reasonable confidence
- The order quantity works with our storage and purchasing plan
- We know which products and sizes need to fit
- We can allow time for artwork, approval, production and delivery
- We are prepared to use accurate certification and disposal wording
- Our brand will benefit from a stronger packaging experience
- We have someone who can own the project internally

10. Quote-ready planning worksheet

Use the worksheet on the next page to turn what you know into a clear first conversation. Complete what you can and leave genuinely open decisions for discussion.

The aim is not to arrive with every answer. It is to give Zero Pack enough context to explore the right packaging and identify what must be confirmed next.

What to check

- What are you packing?
- What job must the packaging do?
- What are the packed product dimensions and weight?
- How many units do you expect to use?
- Where will the packaging be delivered and used?
- What do you want the customer to notice or understand?
- What certification or disposal information is important?
- When do you need the packaging?
- Is artwork ready, in progress or not started?
- What questions still need an expert answer?

Turn what you know into a useful first conversation

Complete what you can. Leave open decisions open - they are useful questions for the project conversation.

01	What are you packing?	_____ _____
02	What job must the packaging do?	_____ _____
03	What are the packed product dimensions and weight?	_____ _____
04	How many units do you expect to use?	_____ _____
05	Where will the packaging be delivered and used?	_____ _____
06	What do you want the customer to notice or understand?	_____ _____
07	What certification or disposal information is important?	_____ _____
08	When do you need the packaging?	_____ _____
09	Is artwork ready, in progress or not started?	_____ _____
10	What questions still need an expert answer?	_____ _____

Claims stay connected to the packaging

This guide is practical planning information, not a substitute for confirming the final packaging specification, certification evidence, production requirements or local disposal pathway.

Certification evidence can be provided on request after the relevant packaging and specification have been confirmed. Local collection and processor rules should be checked before publishing disposal instructions.

Official sources and guidance

AUSTRALIAN REFERENCES	
View AS 5810 information	Standards Australia - home-compostable plastics standard
View AS 4736 information	Standards Australia - commercial-composting and microbial-treatment standard
ABA certification information	Australian verification context for AS 4736 and AS 5810
ACCC environmental claims guidance	Current primary guidance on truthful, accurate and evidence-backed environmental claims
ACCC 2023 guide - additional reading	Earlier detailed guide; the ACCC notes that it does not reflect penalty increases effective 28 March 2026
INTERNATIONAL CERTIFICATION SCHEMES	
OK compost HOME	TÜV AUSTRIA certification information for home-composting conditions
OK compost INDUSTRIAL	TÜV AUSTRIA certification information for industrial-composting conditions

Guide last reviewed: September 2026

Packaging specifications, certification schemes, disposal pathways and regulatory guidance can change. Confirm current project-specific requirements before publishing claims or disposal instructions.

Ready to discuss your packaging?

Bring Zero Pack the packaging problem, or a finished brief. Share the product, likely quantities, destination, artwork status and timing you know so far.

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